BY TEAM DIGIT
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Most people will look to do forward looking stories on the first on January of every year. It's a new year, there are 12 whole months of things that will happen, and in general, readers are psychologically conditioned to accept such stories. We were tempted to go down that expected route too. It's a hell of a lot easier to give you a list of expected launches and rumoured features of the iPhone 8 and Samsung S8, etc. And that's not to say we won't cover those stories online ourselves, but for the magazine, we obviously wanted some depth... something more...

Whilst discussing story ideas we realised that a lot of the things we were discussing were starting off in 2017, or would be first on display in 2017, and this led us to the conclusion that more than any other year before, 2017 paints a much clearer picture of what we can expect in our future. After a really long time of mediocrity, finally 2017 promises to be a year where science and technology will start to wow us again like it used to do 10 or 15 years ago.

Another clarification we should make is that we don't mean "concepts" in the way companies make concept gadgets... those are often just designers going wild with scribbles and are seldom based in reality. The auto industry is famous for concept drawings that look amazing, and then prototypes or actual cars that look nothing like the original drawings, because artists are not engineers, and don't account for real-world scenarios.

When we say concepts, we mean something more broader than a single design. We mean a conceptual shift in the way we will live our lives in the future. And we do mean "we" and not our grandkids, because all of the concepts we're covering are something we expect to see in our lifetimes – as early as within the next five to ten years!

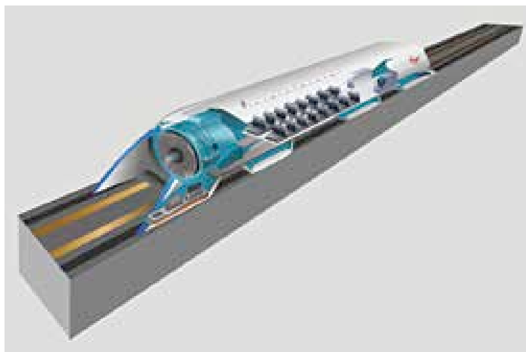
Anyway, enough of the buildup, let's get to the actual concepts. Remember to write in to feedback@digit.in and tell us if we missed out on something, or if you disagree with our concepts, or just want to add something to the story – the best letters will win Digit T-Shirts.

01 RAPID TRANSPORT / TRANSIT

Let's face it, as each year passes, the seriousness of two things increases rapidly – population and climate change. Both are directly proportional as well, because the former usually leads to increased amounts of the latter. With no end in sight for population growth just yet, it's obvious that we need to do other things to control climate change as of now.

One of those things is to deal with transport caused pollution. Rapid transit systems are usually inner city modes of transport – typically metros or subway systems, and they're environmentally better than everyone using their cars to get around the city. However, it's not just people transport that matters, but also cargo, because most large cities are fed with supplies from nearby towns or smaller cities.

Early in 2017, and right throughout, we will see a lot of activity and testing by companies around Elon Musk's Hyperloop challenge. For those who don't know, billionaire Elon Musk, whilst stuck in traffic, wished for a better transport system. While for most of us this remains a daydream, billionaires have the advantage of being able to fund their dreams. He open sourced his idea, and encouraged more companies and scientists to get on board, and get on board they did... by the thousands.



SOURCE: WIKIMEDIA

Hyperloop concept art.

There are currently many interesting candidates from across the globe vying for testing time on the few hyperloop test tracks there are, and 2017 is the year we expect to see many of those tests being conducted. Although we don't see this as being an inner city rapid transit solution, we do see this first being implemented to transport goods between closely situated cities that have a lot of goods and cargo exchange. Sadly, you'll probably need a visa and a flight ticket to see it.

Currently, the first phase of selected finalists for hyperloop testing will be conducted at SpaceX's Hyperloop test track between January 27-29, and then Phase 2 in the summer of 2017.

EXCITING EXAMPLES
http://dgit.in/MIThyprlp
http://dgit.in/vichyper
http://dgit.in/bdgrloop